

41% IN THE 31-40 AGE GROUP SAY THEY'RE FORCED TO HAVE SEX

What is the most important reason for you to have sex?

		MALE	FEMALE
For pleasure	50	57	43
To please my spouse	29	18	39
For children	17	21	14

MUTUAL PLEASURE

The motivation for sex is varied across the country. Those in Mumbai and Delhi want it for pleasure and while in Chennai for children. Patna, with 67%, surprisingly tops the list of cities wanting sex for pleasure.

All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Won't say.



not shy away from depicting the hideousness of rape and female protests to such grievous injustice. The survey demonstrates that some women are not afraid of calling a spade by that name. Marriage and children remain important landmarks in most women's lives. But many today will work—at the expense of considerable hardship—to ensure that the terms on which these goals are met remain just and enjoyable for them.

As social scientists we also need to take serious note of these changes. It is time that we altered our critical vocabulary to recognise that a woman who is vocal about her needs—sexual, emotional, financial—is not an exception in Indian society but an emergent figure fighting for a new definition of sexual norms. Empathy for women's silence was once a respectful form of practice on part of the feminist historian, for silence was treated as a sign of women's condition. Today, there is no reason to say that women are "silent", believing that they do not have any choice in matters affecting their conditions. The media, human rights organisations, women's shelters and associations are making a difference. This survey suggests that women are raising, in the public sphere, questions about the role of consent and pleasure in sexual relations. The future historian of women in this country will have to orient herself to these changed conditions.

The writer is a historian of women and family, and teaches at the University of Chicago

changed with the help of a few episodes of marital rape in recorded Indian history.

On January 9, 1891, the British government passed a law that forbade sexual intercourse with a girl below the age of 12. Historians have noted that this law did not interfere with the practice of child marriage, but with the problem of premature consummation of such marriages. The proper age for heterosexual intercourse became a matter of grave concern for the colonial government and the reformist intelligentsia when a young Bengali girl Phulmonnee died in 1889 after being brutally raped by her 35-year-old husband Hari Mohan Maitee.

Two features of this debate are of interest. First, it was conducted primarily by male spokespersons of both the colonising and the

colonised elite. Second, opponents of the bill argued that the inclusion of a marital rape clause in the Indian Consent Act would be a discriminatory measure as there was no such clause in the British Consent Act. One opponent, Manmohun Ghose, an otherwise progressive man who stood for female education and other reforms for women, argued that colonial policies were intent on humiliating the Indian man and deliberately wanted to include the marital rape provision. It denied the Indian husband "lawful access" to his wife, something guaranteed to the English male through the matrimonial contract.

This debate failed to note what the girl bride or woman felt. Ghose's concerns and the British Consent Act remained silent on the fact that the "lawful"

confines of marriage couldn't stop wives from being raped by some husbands. The law—ironically called "the Age of Consent"—may have made a difference to the age when a wife becomes "accessible" to her husband but did nothing to change the nature of access.

For me, the survey demonstrates a collective feminine will engaged in a struggle to claim for women the right to sexual sovereignty. Gone is the prudery associated with sex. A woman who demands the right to pleasure is no longer an object of scorn and contempt. Contemporary public culture clearly highlights this resolve. We need only to remember Rituporno Ghosh's film *Antarmahal* or Jag Mundhra's *Provoked* to realise that purveyors of modern Indian culture do